

The Virat Kohli story, told by those who know him best

From **Cheeku to champion** — teammates recall Virat Kohli's fierce will to win and unrelenting pursuit of greatness.

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How would you define Virat Kohli? Usually, such questions put people in a fix. But Wriddhiman Saha had no hesitation. "A champion, who always wants to win." The former India wicketkeeper, who played under Kohli's captaincy for seven years, listed his reasons without pause.

"Be it on the field or even on the PlayStation with us, Virat always had that winning mentality. He was never ready to lose without putting in his best efforts. This fierce competitiveness spoke volumes about his character. It explains why he could take India's Test team to a new high," Saha told *Sportstar*.

Kohli led India in 68 Tests — the most by any Indian captain — winning 40, losing 17, and drawing 11. His win percentage of 58.82 is the highest among Indian Test captains.



Abhinav Mukund, (left) who made his Test debut alongside Kohli in 2011, offered a more personal reflection. Having first met him at

an Under-15 national camp, Mukund recalled that Kohli wasn't the best or the fittest then — but his hunger stood out.

Both made it to India's victorious Under-19 World

Cup squad in 2008, where Kohli was captain.

"We hold our Test numbers very dear to our chest. I remember being extremely nervous and sharing that nervousness with Virat," Mukund said on *BBC Stumped*.

"He had already played white-ball cricket for India, but we all understood the importance of Test cricket. Virat wanted to be the best that ever was." He added, **"We had very different journeys as cricketers, but Virat wanted to be the best batter in the team and the best version of himself."**

It wasn't always smooth. Kohli had to wait seven months to score his first Test hundred. Saha, who had a ringside view of that knock in Adelaide in 2012, still remembers the morning vividly. India was reeling at 111 for 5. As Saha walked out to bat, Kohli — playing his eighth Test — approached him.

"He patted me on the back and said, 'Be confident,'" Saha recalled.

"He was very clear about our approach. Australia had posted a mammoth total, and we had lost five wickets. He told me to be in the moment and just play to my